

Harissa Lentil & Chickpea Shepherd's Pie

with Air-Fried Courgette and Mushroom

Serves: 4 (2 portions + leftovers for the next day) **Active time:** ~25 mins **Total:** ~1 hr 15 mins

A smoky, harissa-led vegetarian shepherd's pie. Split red lentils dissolve into the tomato base to thicken it, while a tin of chickpeas keeps the bite. Courgette and chestnut mushrooms are air-fried hard so they hold their texture when folded through, and the whole thing sits under a 50/50 potato and sweet potato mash. Pescatarian-friendly and dairy-free. Improves on day two.

Ingredients

For the mash

- 500g floury potatoes (Maris Piper or King Edward), peeled and chunked
- 500g sweet potatoes, peeled and chunked
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 50ml oat milk
- Salt and black pepper

For the air-fried veg

- 2 medium courgettes, cut into 1.5cm dice
- 250g chestnut mushrooms, quartered
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp soy sauce or tamari
- ½ tsp ground cumin
- ½ tsp smoked paprika

For the lentil & chickpea base

- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 large onion, finely chopped
- 4 garlic cloves, finely chopped
- 2 tsp ground cumin
- 2 tsp ground coriander
- 2 tsp smoked paprika
- 3 tbsp rose harissa (Belazu is the benchmark — start with 2 tbsp if yours is fiercer)
- 1 x 400g tin chopped tomatoes
- 200g red or yellow split lentils, rinsed
- 500ml vegetable stock
- 1 tbsp miso paste (white or brown)
- 1 x 400g tin chickpeas, drained and rinsed
- 1 tbsp sherry vinegar or red wine vinegar
- Small handful of fresh parsley or coriander, chopped

Method

1. **Get the oven and potatoes going.** Preheat the oven to 200°C fan. Put the chopped potatoes and sweet potatoes into a large pan, cover with cold salted water, bring to the boil, then simmer until tender — around 18–20 minutes.
2. **Toss the veg for the air fryer.** In a bowl, toss the diced courgettes and quartered mushrooms with the olive oil, soy sauce, ½ tsp cumin, and ½ tsp smoked paprika. Make sure everything is well coated.
3. **Air fry the courgette and mushrooms.** Spread them into the Ninja air fryer basket — don't overcrowd; do two batches if needed. Cook at 200°C for 14 minutes, shaking halfway. You want proper colour: golden edges on the courgette, mushrooms shrunk and glossy. Set aside.
4. **Sweat the onion.** While the veg are in the air fryer, heat 3 tbsp olive oil in a wide, deep pan over medium-low heat. Add the onion with a pinch of salt and cook gently until soft and translucent — around 8 minutes. Don't rush this; it's the foundation.
5. **Bloom the spices.** Add the garlic, 2 tsp cumin, 2 tsp coriander, 2 tsp smoked paprika, and the rose harissa. Stir constantly for about 90 seconds until everything smells fragrant and the harissa has darkened the oil.
6. **Cook down the tomatoes.** Add the tinned tomatoes and turn the heat up. Let them bubble and reduce hard — you're compensating for not using tomato purée here, so push it for about 5 minutes until the tomatoes thicken and turn a deeper, brick-red colour.
7. **Simmer the lentils.** Stir in the rinsed split lentils, vegetable stock, and miso paste. Bring to a gentle simmer, cover loosely, and cook for around 18 minutes until the lentils have broken down and the base is thick. Stir occasionally to stop it catching on the bottom.
8. **Make the mash.** Drain the potatoes and sweet potatoes, return them to the pan, and mash with 3 tbsp olive oil and 50ml oat milk. Season generously with salt and black pepper. You want it firm enough to hold its shape on top of the filling, not sloppy.
9. **Finish the base.** Stir the chickpeas into the lentil base. Add the sherry vinegar and check seasoning — it should taste savoury, smoky, with a quiet sharpness from the vinegar. Adjust salt and harissa to taste.
10. **Fold in the air-fried veg.** Tip the air-fried courgettes and mushrooms into the base along with the chopped parsley or coriander. Fold gently — you want them held intact, not crushed. The filling should be thick and scoopable, not soupy. If it looks too wet, simmer uncovered for a few more minutes.
11. **Assemble.** Transfer the filling into a baking dish (roughly 25 x 20cm or similar). Spoon the mash on top in dollops, then spread to cover. Rough the surface up with a fork — those peaks crisp up beautifully in the oven.
12. **Bake.** Bake at 200°C fan for 25 minutes, or until the top is golden and crisp and the filling is bubbling at the edges.
13. **Rest before serving.** Let it rest for 5 minutes before serving — it'll firm up and the flavours settle. Serve with your broccoli or cabbage on the side.

Notes

Side veg. Broccoli works well steamed or, better, charred in the air fryer (200°C, 8–10 min with olive oil, salt, and a pinch of chilli) — slot it in while the pie rests. Cabbage is great shredded and fried hard in a little olive oil with caraway or cumin seeds until the edges catch and crisp.

Day two. This improves overnight. Reheat individual portions in the oven at 180°C for 20 minutes covered, then uncovered for the last 5 to re-crisp the top. Alternatively, assemble two smaller dishes and only bake one — the unbaked one keeps better in the fridge and reheats cleaner.

Consistency check. If the filling looks too wet before the mash goes on, simmer it uncovered for a few more minutes — too much liquid will bubble up through the mash. If it looks too thick, splash in a little more stock.

Heat level. Rose harissa varies a lot by brand. 3 tbsp gives a warm, fragrant heat with Belazu. If yours is fiercer, start with 2 tbsp and taste before adding more.